WOLFE

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STARTER GUIDE · USA · CANADA · UK

DATING AGAIN AFTER 40

A calm, practical guide for men starting over after divorce, loss, or a long time single.

DORIAN WOLFE · AI-GENERATED CHARACTER

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Dorian Wolfe is an AI-generated character, not a real person, and has no personal life story. This is general communication advice for adults. It is not therapy, medical, legal or financial advice, and no result is guaranteed. Always respect other people's boundaries and consent.

INTRODUCTION

YOU'RE NOT BEHIND

If you are 40, 50 or 60 and dating again, you may feel out of practice, awkward, or worried that you have missed your chance. That feeling is common. It does not mean something is wrong with you.

What this guide is	A step-by-step plan: get ready, rebuild your circle, meet people, talk, go on dates, handle rejection, set boundaries, stay safe.
What it is not	It is not a set of tricks. There are no lines that make anyone fall for you. It will not make promises about results.
How to use it	Read one chapter a day. Do the "Try this" action at the end. Move at your own pace.

A NOTE ON EVIDENCE

This guide uses general relationship and social-skills research plus common sense. Studies of men over 40 are limited, so treat everything here as practical guidance, not a guarantee. It is not therapy, medical advice, legal advice or financial advice.

CHAPTER 1

ARE YOU READY? A QUICK CHECK

There is no right answer, and no deadline. Use these questions to see where you are.

- [ ] I can talk about my past relationship without anger most of the time.
- [ ] I have friends or activities outside of dating.
- [ ] I want companionship, not just to fill a silence.
- [ ] I can handle someone saying no.
- [ ] I have the time and energy to go on a date.
- [ ] I am willing to be a little awkward at the start.

If you ticked most, you are probably ready to start. If not, go slower and spend more time on chapters 2 and 3 first. Studies of loneliness after divorce or widowhood suggest that a new partner can help, but there is no single timeline that works for everyone.

TRY THIS

Write down one reason you want to date again. Keep it somewhere you can see it.

CHAPTER 2

GRIEF, PACE AND EXPECTATIONS

Let yourself grieve	Divorce, separation or the death of a partner is a loss. Sadness, anger and numbness are normal.
Go at your pace	You do not have to date because others say you should, or avoid dating because others say it is too soon.
Expect awkward moments	You will say the wrong thing sometimes. Smile, laugh, carry on.
One thing at a time	You do not need to rebuild your whole life before a first coffee.

IF YOU ARE WIDOWED

Many widowed people feel guilty when they think about dating. This is common. There is no correct date to start, and your feelings for your late partner do not have to disappear.

IF IT FEELS HEAVIER THAN NERVES

If you feel hopeless, or think about harming yourself, please talk to someone now. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK, Samaritans: 116 123. Elsewhere, findahelpline.com lists local services.

CHAPTER 3

REBUILD YOUR CIRCLE FIRST

After a divorce, many men find their social life shrank. Loneliness is hard on its own, and it makes dating feel higher-stakes. Rebuilding friendships takes pressure off.

- Message one old friend and suggest a coffee or a walk.
- Join a group: walking club, running club, volunteering, a class, a men's shed, a faith or community group.
- Say yes to invitations, even when you feel like staying home.
- Tell one trusted person you are thinking of dating again.

TRY THIS

This week, message one friend and make one plan.

CHAPTER 4

YOUR STORY IN 30 SECONDS

Someone says, "Tell me about yourself," and your mind goes blank. Use **Present, Past, Passion** and keep it under 30 seconds.

Present	What you do now, in one line.
Past	One interesting thing that shaped you.
Passion	Something you enjoy, said with energy.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

> **I run a small landscaping business. I grew up near the coast, so I am happiest outdoors. Lately I am trying to get better at cooking, with mixed results. What about you?**
>
> Then hand it back

- ✕ Do not recite your CV.
- ✕ Do not list achievements.
- ✕ Do not turn it into a monologue.

TRY THIS

Write and say your 30-second story out loud three times.

CHAPTER 5

TALKING ABOUT YOUR EX AND YOUR KIDS

You do not have to hide your past, but you do not have to tell it all on the first date either.

ABOUT YOUR EX: WHAT YOU COULD SAY (ILLUSTRATIVE)

We wanted different things. It ended, and I learned a lot from it.

Short, calm, no blame

- ✕ Complaining about your ex for more than a sentence or two.
- ✕ Details of the divorce, money or legal fights.
- ✕ Comparing her to your ex.

ABOUT YOUR KIDS: WHAT YOU COULD SAY (ILLUSTRATIVE)

I have two kids. They are a big part of my life, and I am proud of them.

Honest and positive

Introducing kids to someone new is a big step. Many people wait until the relationship is steady and exclusive. There is no fixed rule, so go at the pace that is right for your family.

CHAPTER 6

WHERE TO MEET PEOPLE AFTER 40

In person	Friends of friends, classes, volunteering, hobby clubs, faith groups, running or walking groups, community events.
Online	Apps and sites such as OurTime, SilverSingles, Match or eharmony. Prices and features vary, so check each site.
A mix	Do both. Online dating is common, but in a 2022 Pew survey only about 17% of adults 50+ had ever used a dating app, so many people still meet in person.

TRY THIS

Pick one in-person activity you would enjoy anyway, and go this week.

CHAPTER 7

USING DATING APPS SAFELY

- [ ] Use a recent photo and be honest about age.
- [ ] Video call before meeting.
- [ ] Meet in a public place and tell a friend.
- [ ] Keep your address, workplace and finances private.
- [ ] Never send money, gift cards or crypto.
- [ ] Be wary of anyone who rushes to another app or says "I love you" quickly.

LEARN MORE

People 60+ reported about $2.4 billion in fraud losses to the FTC in 2024 (all fraud types). See the free Scam Red-Flag Checklist and the Scam-Proof Dating Guide for 50+.

CHAPTER 8

PHOTOS AND BIO BASICS

Photos	Four to six clear, recent photos: a smiling headshot, a full-body shot, you doing something you enjoy, one with friends. Good light helps. Avoid hats and sunglasses in every photo.
Bio	Two or three short sentences: what you enjoy, what you are looking for, and an easy question to answer.
Tone	Positive and specific. Avoid lists of dislikes or complaints about past partners.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

Weekend hiker, terrible cook, decent listener. Looking for someone to laugh with and explore new places. Tell me the best meal you have had this year.

- ✕ Old photos.
- ✕ Lying about age, height or looks.
- ✕ "No drama" or "no games" as your headline.

CHAPTER 9

THE FIRST MESSAGE

Many men feel they get too few messages. In a 2023 Pew survey of online daters (all ages), 64% of men said they felt insecure about getting too few. You are not alone. A better first message helps.

1. Be specific	Mention one thing from her profile.
2. Ask one easy question	Something she can answer in a sentence.
3. Keep it short and warm	Two or three lines.

That photo from the lake: please tell me it was as good as it looks.

I liked what you said about gardening. What are you growing this year?

Best coffee spot you have found lately? I need a recommendation.

- ✕ Just "hi" or "hey".
- ✕ Compliments about her body.
- ✕ Copy-pasted messages.

CHAPTER 10

KEEP THE CONVERSATION GOING

A conversation stays alive when you show interest and share something of yourself. Use **Echo, Dig, Share**.

Echo	Repeat a key word she said, with curiosity. "Lisbon! What took you there?"
Dig	Ask what she liked or why. "What was the best part?"
Share	Offer a short story or opinion of your own.

THE 1:1 RULE

For every question you ask, share one thing about yourself. This stops it feeling like an interview.

When she tells you something personal: acknowledge it, say back what you heard, ask a gentle question, and share briefly. Do not try to fix it or turn it into your story.

CHAPTER 11

THE FIRST DATE

Choose a simple plan	Coffee or a walk. 60 to 90 minutes. Public place.
Arrive early	Phone on silent, put away.
Start light	Talk about the place, the journey, something easy.
Then go warmer	Interests, travel, food, work you enjoy.
Share, don't interview	Use the 1:1 rule.
End on a high	Leave while it is going well. Say you enjoyed it, and whether you would like to meet again.

10 QUESTIONS TO TRY

1. What was the best part of your week?
2. What do you do to unwind?
3. What was your favourite trip?
4. What are you looking forward to?
5. What is a hobby you would do all day?
6. What did you enjoy about growing up where you did?
7. What is a skill you would love to learn?
8. What makes you laugh?
9. What is a good day like for you?
10. What matters to you most right now?

CHAPTER 12

AFTER THE DATE

Send a message within a day. Do not play games.

I had a great time today. I would like to see you again. Free Saturday?

If you are interested

Thank you for meeting me. I enjoyed meeting you, but I do not think we are a match. I wish you well.

If you are not

If she is not interested, thank her and let it go.

CHAPTER 13

REJECTION AND GHOSTING

It is information about fit	It is not a verdict on your worth.
Take a short break	Walk, talk to a friend, do something you enjoy.
Learn one thing	Then move on. Do not argue or ask "why" repeatedly.
Ghosting	Send one light message if you wish, then let it go.

For more, see the Rejection and Resilience guide and the "She Went Quiet" guide.

CHAPTER 14

BOUNDARIES AND PACE

A boundary is a calm statement about what you need or are comfortable with. It is not a punishment or a threat.

I am enjoying this, and I would like to take it slowly.

I am not comfortable with that, but I would love to do something else.

I would like to be exclusive. How do you feel about that?

A clear, kind question

Respect hers too. If she says no or slows things down, accept it without argument.

CHAPTER 15

IS THIS RELATIONSHIP HEALTHY?

SIGNS OF HEALTH

- You can be yourself.
- She respects your time, friends and boundaries.
- Both of you share and listen.
- Disagreements are handled calmly.
- Your words and actions match.

WARNING SIGNS

- ✕ Rapid, intense flattery followed by control or withdrawal.
- ✕ Blame, guilt or dismissing your feelings.
- ✕ Pressure about money, secrecy or isolation from friends.
- ✕ A story that keeps changing.

IF YOU FEEL UNSAFE

Emotional pressure, intimidation or violence are not normal. In the US, the National Domestic Violence Hotline is 1-800-799-7233.

CHAPTER 16

YOUR 30-DAY STARTER PLAN

- [ ] Week 1: Message one friend. Join one group or activity. Write your 30-second story.
- [ ] Week 1: Take three new photos in good light.
- [ ] Week 2: Write or refresh your bio. Read the scam checklist.
- [ ] Week 2: Send two thoughtful first messages.
- [ ] Week 3: Keep two conversations going with Echo, Dig, Share.
- [ ] Week 3: Suggest one coffee or walk.
- [ ] Week 4: Go on a first date, or a friendly practice meet-up.
- [ ] Week 4: Review what went well and what to try next.

NEXT STEP

For a daily plan with worksheets, see the 30-Day Confidence Challenge.

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SUPPORT FOR DIVORCE, GRIEF AND RELATIONSHIPS

Starting again is easier with people around you. These services are for the stage before dating, or alongside it.

USA and Canada	**DivorceCare** (divorcecare.org) and **GriefShare** (griefshare.org) run local group programmes, often in churches. Fees and style vary. Some are faith-based.
UK	**Relate** (relate.org.uk) offers relationship counselling. Local centres set their own fees. **Cruse Bereavement Support:** 0808 808 1677.

A NOTE ON COUNSELLING

A licensed counsellor or therapist can help in ways a guide cannot. In the UK you can ask your GP or look for a BACP-registered counsellor. In the USA and Canada, ask your doctor or search a licensed-professional directory in your state or province.

CHECK FIRST

Numbers and hours change. If one fails, search the service's official website.

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DATING CUSTOMS: WHAT IS NORMAL WHERE YOU LIVE

Customs vary by city, age and background. Surveys on them are small and often company-run, and I found none on first dates for over-35s, so treat this as common practice and be kind.

Who pays

Surveys disagree. In US polls, answers were split between "the man", "whoever asked" and "split it". A UK survey found "split evenly" the most common answer. The safe move in all three countries: offer to split, or say "this one is on me, next one is yours", and accept a no kindly.

What to call it

In the USA and Canada people say "date" fairly early. In the UK, "meeting up" or "going for a drink" is common before anyone says "date". Match the other person's word.

Where to meet

A public place, in daylight, that you chose or know. Tell a friend where you are going and when you will message them. This is general safety advice, not a rule of any one country.

Apps

Pew (USA, 2022) found Tinder, Match and Bumble the most used among online daters. UK figures (Ofcom, 2024) show Tinder, Hinge and Bumble with the largest reach, and that Plenty of Fish and Badoo skew towards ages 35 to 54. No reliable ranking for Canada was found. Pick the app where people your age actually are.

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WHERE TO GET HELP

IF YOU FEEL HOPELESS OR UNSAFE

USA	**988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline.** Call or text 988, or chat at 988lifeline.org/chat. Free, 24/7. Emergency: 911.
Canada	**9-8-8 Suicide Crisis Helpline.** Call or text 988, 24/7, in English and French. Info: 988.ca. Emergency: 911.
UK	**Samaritans:** 116 123 (free, 24/7). **Shout:** text SHOUT to 85258. **NHS 111** for urgent mental-health help (choose the mental-health option). Emergency: 999.

IF A PARTNER OR EX FRIGHTENS YOU

USA	**National Domestic Violence Hotline:** 1-800-799-7233, or text START to 88788. thehotline.org. Internet use can be monitored: use a safe device.
Canada	There is no single national line. Find your province at **canada.ca** (search "gender-based violence crisis lines") or look up shelters at **sheltersafe.ca**. Emergency: 911.
UK	**National Domestic Abuse Helpline:** 0808 2000 247 (free, 24/7). **Men's Advice Line:** 0808 801 0327 for men experiencing abuse. If you cannot speak on a 999 call, press 55.

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IF YOU THINK YOU ARE BEING SCAMMED

Stop contact. Do not send more money. Tell your bank or card company straight away, keep the messages and screenshots, and report it. Shame keeps scams going: you are not the first, and reporting helps.

USA	Report to the FTC at **reportfraud.ftc.gov** and to the FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center at **ic3.gov**. If you sent money, tell your bank or card company straight away.
Canada	Report to the **Canadian Anti-Fraud Centre: 1-888-495-8501**, or online at antifraudcentre-centreantifraude.ca. If you lost money, also contact your local police and your bank.
UK	Report to **Report Fraud: reportfraud.police.uk, 0300 123 2040** (England, Wales and Northern Ireland; in Scotland call Police Scotland on 101). It replaced Action Fraud in December 2025. To reach your own bank's fraud team, **dial 159**.

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BE CALM.

BE CURIOUS.

BE REAL.

— Dorian Wolfe